

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **The FCC approved** Skydance Entertainment's merger with Paramount Global, clearing the way for the more than \$8 billion deal to close as the entertainment industry pins its hopes for the future on consolidation. **B1**
- ◆ **Intel detailed** dramatic steps to revive its sagging fortunes, outlining layoffs of 15% of its workforce and scrapping plans to spend tens of billions of dollars on new chip facilities in Europe. **B1**
- ◆ **Nestlé said it was** considering selling Nature's Bounty and other brands in its vitamins business as part of its efforts to boost sales growth. **B1**
- ◆ **The European** Central Bank paused its most aggressive interest-rate cutting campaign since the global financial crisis as it awaits clarity on Trump's tariffs. **A8**
- ◆ **The U.S. economy** and its peers in Europe and Asia continued to show resilience amid high levels of uncertainty about the future of trade and international relations. **A8**
- ◆ **The Nasdaq and S&P** 500 extended their run of records, advancing 0.2% and less than 0.1%, respectively, while the Dow industrials retreated 0.7%. **B10**
- ◆ **UnitedHealth said it** was responding to requests from civil and criminal investigators at the Justice Department following media reports of probes into its Medicare business. **B3**
- ◆ **Roche discussed selling** drugs directly to patients in talks with U.S. officials following Trump administration calls for the industry to cut prices. **B3**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Trump toured the Fed's** construction site in what amounted to political theater designed to amplify pressure on the central bank in pursuit of the president's goal of lower interest rates. **A1, A2**
- ◆ **The U.S. has collected** an additional \$55 billion in tariffs this year, paid for largely by U.S. businesses that are absorbing much of the costs for now. **A1**
- ◆ **Bill Clinton was among** around five dozen people, including billionaire Leon Black, fashion designer Vera Wang and media owner Mort Zuckerman, who ended up with letters in Jeffrey Epstein's birthday album. **A1**
- ◆ **Deputy Attorney General** Todd Blanche met with Ghislaine Maxwell, the imprisoned longtime confidante of Jeffrey Epstein. **A4**
- ◆ **Chevron is regaining** the ability to pump oil in Venezuela from the Trump administration in an abrupt reversal of White House policy. **A3**
- ◆ **Middle East envoy** Steve Witkoff said he recalled the U.S. negotiating team from Qatar for consultations, saying Hamas lacked the desire to reach a cease-fire in Gaza. **A7**
- ◆ **A Russian plane** carrying scores of people crashed while attempting to land in a mountainous region of Russia's far east, leaving no survivors. **A7**
- ◆ **Wisconsin's Democratic** Gov. Tony Evers said he wouldn't seek a third term in the 2026 election in the battleground state. **A4**
- ◆ **Died: Hulk Hogan**, 71, professional wrestler. **A12**... **Chuck Mangione**, 84, jazz master. **A4**

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President Trump and Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell toured the Fed's headquarters renovation Thursday in Washington.

Asbestos, Toxic Soil, Inflation Drive Up Fed Renovation Costs

Yearslong project in Washington swells to \$2.5 billion, spurs attacks by Trump

WASHINGTON—The Federal Reserve's headquarters renovation was ambitious from the start: refurbish and modernize

By Nicole Friedman, Nancy Keates and Nick Timiraos

two stately, nearly century-old buildings in a major city. Then it hit the swamp. Higher-than-expected groundwater lurked beneath the site, situated around former

wetlands, and needed to be drained. There was also asbestos, and toxic contamination in the soil. All of that, combined with rising costs of materials from pandemic shortages and inflation, pushed up the cost of the renovations. A project with an estimated budget of \$1.9 billion in 2023 ballooned to \$2.5 billion by 2025.

But it is more than a monster renovation headache. The staggering cost has given the Fed's critics an opening to push for changes at the central bank and a fresh line of attack against Fed Chair Jerome Powell. President Trump and administration officials, who have grown frustrated that the Fed hasn't lowered interest rates

faster, have blasted the expensive renovation, calling it unnecessarily lavish. Trump has even suggested he could try to fire Powell as a result.

Trump toured the Fed's construction site Thursday afternoon with White House advisers—including Powell's most vocal critics—ramping up the pressure campaign on the Fed chair.

Reporters were escorted through the construction site Thursday morning, where between 700 and 800 workers across two shifts are on the job. The tour showcased how security upgrades, including blast-resistant windows, have been another large driver of costs. Erecting a brand-new build-

ing would have been cheaper than renovating two historic buildings, Fed staff said.

Opponents have said the finishings are too elaborate, criticizing features like a "garden terrace." The Fed said it has cut back on some design elements, and that the garden terrace is a ground-level lawn on top of underground parking. The goal of the renovations, the Fed said, is to update and modernize the buildings and preserve some elegant, original features such as stonework.

Architects and construction experts said cost overruns are

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◆ **Trump takes pressure** campaign to the Fed..... **A2**

Epstein Album Had Clinton, Leon Black

By KHADEEJA SAFDAR AND JOE PALAZZOLO

The biggest name in Jeffrey Epstein's birthday book back in 2003 was a past president rather than a future one.

Epstein's former girlfriend Ghislaine Maxwell was keen for Bill Clinton and other boldface names to submit letters for the special gift, according to people involved in putting it together.

In the end, she was successful. The leather-bound album— assembled before Epstein was first arrested in 2006— included a page with a single paragraph in Clinton's distinctive scrawl:

It's reassuring isn't it, to have

lasted as long, across all the years of learning and knowing, adventures and [illegible word], and also to have your childlike curiosity, the drive to make a difference and the solace of friends.

A spokesman for Clinton declined to comment on the birthday message, which was reviewed by the Journal. He referred the Journal to a previous statement that the former president had cut off ties more than a decade before Epstein was arrested in 2019 and didn't know about Epstein's alleged crimes.

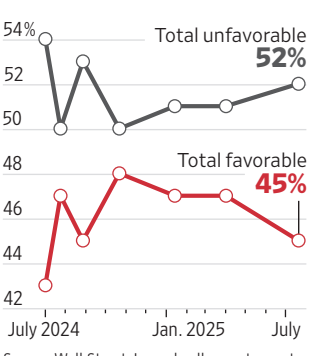
The former president was among around five dozen people

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President's Support Holds

WSJ poll finds economic hope is offsetting an unpopular tax bill and tariffs. **A6**

'Do you have a favorable or unfavorable opinion of Donald Trump?'



Source: Wall Street Journal polls, most recent of 1,500 registered voters, conducted July 16-20; margin of error: +/- 2.5 pct. pts.

On China, Trump Shifts to Deal Mode

By LINGLING WEI

As the U.S. heads toward fresh trade talks with China next week, President Trump is increasingly focused on trying to strike an economic bargain that opens the Asian giant more for U.S. business and technology.

For much of this year, the administration has used the pressure of tariffs to reorient supply chains away from China. The goal has been to weaken Beijing's geopolitical influence and press American businesses to bring back manufacturing jobs to the U.S.

Now, people familiar with

White House thinking said, he wants to do deals.

The White House is now actively encouraging China to buy more U.S. technology, underscored by the lifting of a ban this month on sales of Nvidia's H20 artificial-intelligence chips to Beijing, reversing a policy aimed at protecting U.S. national security.

"The president wants an economic deal, and he's pushing very hard to negotiate that deal," said Stephen Biegun, who served as deputy secretary

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◆ **EU and China spar over** trade, Ukraine..... **A8**

The New Rules of Dating: Less Ghosting, More Dumping

Singles who think it's rude to go silent after one date send breakup texts instead

By KATHERINE BINDLEY

Hannah George was once ghosted by a man she'd been seeing for several weeks. She never wanted to make anyone else feel that way, so she adopted a new approach: texting guys after mediocre first dates to say she wasn't interested.

Recently, the 24-year-old nutrition assistant in New York was on the receiving end of such a text. A man she'd been out with once sent a paragraph-long message about how he'd just spent time with his family, how it had made him nervous about what he wanted in a relationship and

how he just couldn't be with her.

"I thought it was a little bit too long," says George. "You didn't mean this much to me."

There's a moment after a dud of a first date—and definitely after a bad one—when the disappointed parties think to themselves: I really hope I don't hear from that person again. The odds of that are getting slimmer.

Singles are practically racing to let their online matches know that they aren't a match.

Now please don't get them wrong: They think you're

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A Russian Soldier Fights to Survive War

The reality of Moscow's brutal tactics in Ukraine came as a shock

By MATTHEW LUXMOORE

Mikhail Simdyankin was taking the bus to work in St. Petersburg last summer when he passed army recruitment billboards promising generous payouts to those willing to do "real man's work."

The college graduate enjoyed a middle-class life in Russia's cultural capital, where he lived with his wife, Ksenia, a beauty salon worker, and their dog and two cats. He had a good job as a stock manager at a warehouse—but he also had unpaid utility bills. The mili-

tary signing bonus dwarfed his monthly pay of around 90,000 rubles, or \$1,100.

The bonus kept going up. In July 2024, it was 1.3 million rubles. Several weeks later, it passed 1.7 million. After returning home from work one evening he told Ksenia: "If it goes to 2 million, I'm signing up."

He had to wait only three days.

Ksenia pleaded with him not to go. He thought the military would let him serve in the rear, given his lack of combat experience. The little

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INSIDE



JASON GAY

Hulk Hogan is gone—but his influence in sports is everywhere. **A12**

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Regulators approve \$8 billion Paramount deal with Skydance. **B1**